

scan inbound and outbound traffic on SMTP, IMAP, and NNTP (newsgroups) can be set. A heuristic tab allows for checking for suspicious mail by their features rather than any viral pattern. Under this tab, the program can be set to alert the user when any program sends frequent e-mails or mass e-mails, or when the filenames have too many blank spaces—a common technique to hide the actual file extension from showing up (such as “readme.txt.exe”).

Similarly, options for the other modules—P2P, Outlook, and Network Shield can also be set. It needs to be noted that while the Network Shield operates similar to a firewall, by Avast!’s own admission, it cannot be seen as a replacement for a dedicated firewall.

The Web Shield module operates as a proxy server, and in Windows XP requires no tweaking of the browser since it monitors port 80, the default port used for Web traffic. In older OSes, browsers need to be configured to connect through it (IP 127.0.0.1, port 12080). This module acts as a preventive measure, detecting malicious files before they are downloaded. A URL-blocking function can also be used to prevent specific sites from sending data.

Avast! offers updates on a daily basis, and most updates are a few KB in size.

5.4.3 AVG AntiVirus

The free version of AVG offers an e-mail scanner along with the anti-virus. There are fewer modules to configure in comparison with Avast!. It includes a Scheduler, which allows a scan to be scheduled at a particular time.

Under the Tests menu, various scan parameters can be specified. By default, AVG automatically heals infected files, and



The AVG Extended Mode control panel